

can still use it, though it might slow down considerably. Communication between the hacker and the computer travels through back channels of the targeted system, keeping these processes hidden from the owner.

The hacker will sell the target laptop access to others and others can use it for their own purpose. If a spammer has gained access to the target PC, he can use it to send spam. It allows spammers to avoid detection and presumably reduces their bandwidth costs. Since the owners of zombies pay for their own bandwidth, zombies have been used extensively to send e-mail spam; as of 2005, an estimated 50–80 per cent of all spam worldwide was sent by zombie computers. The user might find that his Internet Service Provider (ISP) has cancelled his service, or even that he's under investigation for criminal activity. Meanwhile, the cracker shrugs off the loss of one of his zombies because he has more.

Browser hijacker

A browser hijacker or hijackware is a type of malware program that alters your computer's browser settings so that you're redirected to web sites you had no intention of visiting. Most of the time, it will modify your homepage, error page or search page. It can disable your internet option therefore you can't change the homepage to the default homepage. Furthermore, the browser hijacker will edit the registry therefore it can run each time you restart Windows.

This is generally done by crackers to redirect traffic to their web site or their client's web site which pays for the traffic it generates. More aggressive versions can add pornographic bookmarks or pop-ups which can be a nightmare for your corporate life. Browser hijackers are installed as a part of "freeware" installations and the hijackware is disguised as an add-on to it. It's mentioned in the user agreement but the problem is that users typically ignore the End user Licence Agreement (EULA). A browser hijacker may also be installed without user permission, as the result of an infected e-mail, a file share, or a drive-by download. It's advisable to read the user agreement, be careful what freeware you download off the internet and not click on links in suspicious emails or on social networks.

Phishing

The first documented use of the word "phishing" was in 1996. Most people believe it originated as an alternative spelling of "fishing," as in "to fish for information". Phishing email messages, web sites and phone calls are mainly designed to steal money. For example, if a phisher wants